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Playing on the mother-ground

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Section Title(S): SUMMARY AND CONCLUSIONS

The "elders" in a dispute add two substantial speech elements to the contest, jokes and proverbs. These jokes and proverbs are designed to wound the speaker, to lower his or her esteem in the eyes of the audience. The use of joking is begun early by young boys, and at times it is difficult to distinguish between joking and abusing. A boy may make a joke about another boy, "He walks like a goat," which evokes laughter from other boys in the group. The boy thus attacked is angry and may respond with, "Your father's big penis," which is an expression of abuse. There are, in other words, no jokes told that do not have an obvious "victim." Proverbs are not used as such by children. In playing *Kolo*, however, they do acquire a substantial store of proverbs, which they may later use in talking matter. Proverbs and, to a lesser extent, jokes involve both language and ideology. That is, both are structured speech events, and both can take on extended meaning (i.e., ideology) when used in disputes. Children learn the syntax of proverbs and jokes in their play, but learning the semantics or meanings of jokes and proverbs comes only through exposure to and participation in adult play and talking matter.

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Up to this point, I have described cultural routines that function indirectly in preparing children for adulthood. These are stories of play. In the next chapter we turn to situations in which children learn to do adult work by doing child work. That is, the Kpelle, like most societies that use some means other than schooling to enculturate, have an exquisitely detailed program of chores for children that are graded by age and gender. Chapter 8, considers the chore curriculum.

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